

you want. To edit settings, you have to open the respective `.conf` file directly and edit it yourself. This struck me as geeky. It's not really difficult to do this as there is a good wiki online and a strong community that will help you do it. For instance, to configure the X window system, you have to directly edit the `/etc/X11/xorg.conf` file (if you have installed X). Yes, a simple `xorg-config` would do the job as well, but there is nothing like configuring it yourself. Coming back to configurability, the repository has many desktop environments and window managers—including the popular ones like GNOME, KDE, XFCE, LXDE and window managers like Xmonad. Since you install only the packages you'll need, you will set up a system that will serve your needs, exactly.

4. **Pacman:** It has a wonderful package/update manager and a nice repository. Pacman, the package/update manager written by Judd Vinet himself, is one of the best I've seen and installs all dependencies for a software package. Though it is not a 'killer app', which is the term used to describe the mighty `apt-get`, it is still better than many other package managers. Another advantage is that it can be used to update the system as well.
 - `pacman -S package_name` downloads and installs the package (gzipped tarballs),
 - `pacman -Sy` syncs the local database of packages, and
 - `pacman -Su` updates the system.
5. **Ext4:** The latest filesystem was made available here, before the so-called prominent distros.
6. **Stability:** The distro manages to strike a balance between the latest software and stability, with ease. Some bugs do come up here and there, but they aren't fatal to the computer and are patched soon after they are reported. I've encountered few bugs in the OS. The disadvantages of Arch, according to me, are:
 1. **Minimalist:** Yes, this also is a disadvantage. The system takes time to set up. It takes a few hours to install the base system, put X on top of it, and then a desktop environment on top of X. But hey, once the system is set, it works smooth as silk. You don't have to touch your installation CD again.
 2. You can tell me...

Installation process

I'm going to tell you how to install an Arch base system from a core CD image, with the X window system and GNOME as the desktop environment. If you need instructions on setting up KDE and XFCE, the online wiki pages will come to your rescue.

You can download the latest version, i.e., 2009.02, from www.archlinux.org/download. There is an FTP install version also where you can download just the installer, which, in turn, will download the core packages from a server when you run it. Also, there are full CD, USB and ISOLINUX images available for both i686 and x86_64 targets.

I used Deluge [a Bit Torrent client] to download it and found a good number of people seeding the ISO. Thanks to

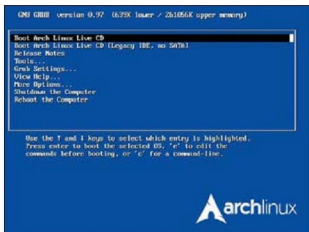


Figure 1: Arch's live CD boot menu



Figure 2: Arch installer



Figure 3: cfdisk partition program

that, I was done with the download in less than an hour.

After burning the ISO to a disc, place it in your CD-ROM drive, and reboot the PC. You'll be presented with a self-explanatory GRUB-like menu. I chose the first option that says "Boot Arch Live". This will load the live system, and you'll be presented with a console log-in. Just type in 'root' for the user name—this is the default log-in and you don't require a password at the moment.

Now that you've logged in, type `/arch/setup` to start the installer.

Step 1: Selecting the source for packages. Since I downloaded a full core image, I chose the first option here, which is, "CD-ROM or other source". There is a second option available called "FTP/HTTP" (for the FTP install CD image)